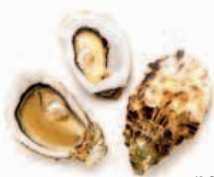




SOUTH ISLAND NEW ZEALAND

Bluff Oysters on South Island

New Zealand's South Island is wild and stunningly beautiful, with coves, fjords, and cliffs framing the cool, pristine waters of the Tasman Sea and Foveaux Strait. The cool-climate conditions at the island's southernmost point have produced some fascinating wildlife and delicious foodstuffs, and it's the world-renowned Bluff oysters that attract visitors from around the world.



The town of Bluff runs along the edge of New Zealand's most southerly peninsula, sheltered by the high range of hills that reach a peak in the old volcanic cone of "Old

Man Bluff," or Bluff Hill. The South Island's State Highway No. 1 ends just outside town, where the waters of the Foveaux Strait lap around the Bluff Scenic Reserve – or Motupōhue – and its Glory Walking Track. From the summit of Bluff Hill there are panoramic views across the strait to Stewart Island, which offer a rare chance of glimpsing one of the rarest whales in the world, the southern right whale (*tohorā*), or the charming little blue penguin (*titi*).

For most of the year, Bluff is a sleepy addendum to the livelier nearby city of Invercargill, and it's inhabited by hardy folks who celebrate living at the extremity of a country. But from May to August each year, this laid-back town becomes the focus for the world's oyster lovers. *Tiostrea chilensis* oysters have been harvested commercially in New Zealand's deep south since the 1860s, originally off Stewart Island, but closer to Bluff from the 1880s, giving the oysters their name. Today, up to 10 million of the succulent bivalves are gathered annually, and they are considered to be

the finest oysters in the world. The first catches of the year take place in early March, and the boats' return is eagerly awaited. In the restaurants of Auckland, a dozen of these delicious oysters cost more than NZ\$50, but in Invercargill and Bluff, seafood suppliers sell the same number for less than half the price.

Tourists lucky enough to visit the area in May can attend the annual Bluff Oyster & Food Festival, which is proudly promoted with the tagline "Unsophisticated and proud of it!" The day's oyster-opening and -eating competitions are appetizers to heaped plates of local crayfish, *paua* (abalone), scallops, and blue cod, and of course more Bluff oysters. Around 20,000 are eaten at the festival, all washed down with the fine wines of the Central Otago vineyards or local beers such as the Pitch Black stout of the Invercargill Brewing Company.

Bluff's easy-going southern ambience infuses travel throughout the surrounding region. To the west lies the dreamlike scenery of the Fiordland National Park. In a country of astounding landscapes, Fiordland trumps everywhere else, with its jagged mountain peaks, fjords, lakes, vast alpine river valleys, and beautiful walking tracks. To the east, the isolated coves and cliff-top lookouts of the Catlins coast provide the perfect places for impromptu seafood picnics.

Three Days on the Southern Scenic Route

This is a region of astonishing natural beauty – allow plenty of time to be captivated by the views and charmed by some of the southern hemisphere's most engaging wildlife.

DAY ONE From **Dunedin** head south along the rugged **Catlins** coastline. At **Roaring Bay**, *hoiho* (yellow-eyed penguins) waddle from the ocean at dusk. At **Papatowai**, visit Blair Sommerville's quirky **Lost Gypsy** gallery. Detour to the spectacular **Cathedral Caves**, then look for dolphins in the surf along the graceful sweep of **Porpoise Bay**.

DAY TWO Explore **Invercargill**. The **Southland Museum** has a great display of tuatara, New Zealand's reptiles, which haven't changed in 220 million years. Catch the ferry from nearby **Bluff** to **Stewart Island** for an opportunity to see kiwis in the wild.

DAY THREE Continue west to the **Fiordland National Park**. Head for **Doubtful Sound** to go kayaking in a beautifully isolated spot – just getting there takes a languid combination of two boats and a bus. Or visit **Milford Sound**, punctuated by the iconic profile of **Mitre Peak**, the spectacular end point for the Milford Track.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Dunedin has regular **flights** from Auckland, New Zealand's main international airport. The airport has a **bus** shuttle and **car** rental.

WHERE TO STAY

Living Space (inexpensive) has sleek rooms in a restored 1907 warehouse. www.livingspace.net

Nugget Lodge (moderate) has two beachfront cabins in the Catlins. www.nuggetlodge.co.nz

Te Anau Lodge (expensive) is a luxurious and stately B&B that was originally built as a convent in the 1930s. www.teanaulodge.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

www.southernscenicroute.co.nz

